

Farmers, container makers disagree

Should bioplastics be allowed in compost feedstock? USDA weighs the question.

By SUSANNE RUST

Greg Pryor began composting yard and food waste for San Francisco in 1996, and today he oversees nine industrial-sized composting sites in California and Oregon that turn discarded banana peels, coffee grounds, chicken bones and more into a dark, nutrient-rich soil that farmers covet for their fields and crops.

His company, Recology, processes organic waste from cities and municipalities across the Bay Area, Central Valley, Northern California, Oregon and Washington — part of a growing movement to reduce greenhouse gas emissions by minimizing food waste in landfills.

But, said Pryor, if bioplastic and compostable food packaging manufacturers get their way, the whole system could collapse.

At issue is a 2021 California law, known as Assembly Bill 1201, which requires that products labeled “compostable” must actually break down into compost, not contaminate soil or crops with toxic chemicals, and be readily identifiable to both consumers and solid waste facilities.

The law also stipulates that products carrying a “compostable” label must meet the U.S. Department of Agriculture’s National Organic Program requirements, which only allow for plant and animal material in compost feedstock, and bar all synthetic substances and materials — plastics, bioplastics and most packaging materials — except for newspaper or other recycled materials.

[See [Compost](#), A6]

‘This is one of the hardest things to predict that’s becoming worse faster than almost anything else in a warming climate.’

— DANIEL SWAIN, climate scientist



CAMP MYSTIC was one of the many areas hit by the flash flood in Hunt, Texas.

Texas flood puts climate, disaster readiness in focus

Federal cuts could leave states at greater risk in the years ahead, experts say.

By HAYLEY SMITH

The tragic Fourth of July flash flood in Texas that has killed at least 78 people is shining a spotlight on the nation’s growing vulnerability to climate disaster.

As rescue crews continue their frantic search for missing children along the Guadalupe River, experts warn that similar incidents could continue to happen as

the federal government slashes funding for weather forecasting, shuts down climate websites and databases, lays off scientists and researchers and weakens disaster response capabilities at a moment when climate change is increasing the frequency of such events.

That includes California, where the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration and its subsidiary, the National Weather Service, are reeling from cutbacks ordered by the Trump administration. In May, at least two California offices of the NWS said they no longer have enough staff to operate overnight: Hanford and Sacramento, which together

cover nearly all of the Central Valley and the Sierra Nevada, some of the state’s most fire-and-flood-prone areas.

Nationally, more than 600 scientists and meteorologists have already been laid off or taken a buyout from NOAA this year. The Trump administration is planning to cut thousands more employees next year — approximately 17% of its workforce — and slash the agency’s budget by more than \$1.5 billion, according to the fiscal 2026 budget request. The president has said the changes will help reduce federal waste and save taxpayers money.

[See [Climate](#), A6]

Frustration with State Farm rises over fire claims

A California inquiry adds to pressure on the insurer amid complaints, lawsuits.

By LAURENCE DARMIENTO

In the aftermath of the Eaton fire, Amy Harrity and her husband were stunned to discover that their Altadena home of three years was still standing, even as dozens of houses in their neighborhood burned to the ground around it.

The fierce firestorm cracked a window of the three-bedroom ranch house, carrying in debris, soot and ash, which also accumulated at the base of doors and other windows; but that was little, they figured, compared with the loss many neighbors endured.

“The immediate response was that we were blessed and what did we do to deserve this. And then we quickly realized that it’s sort of its own unique version of grief in hell, if you want to call it that,” said Harrity, who is living with her family temporarily in the San Francisco Bay Area.

The 40-year-old mother of two young children blames the family’s troubles on its insurer, State Farm General, which she has

wrangled with for months over the remediation needed to make the Navarro Avenue home livable again — with little progress to show for it.

The family had to pay \$7,000 to board up the home and do hygienic testing, which came back positive for lead and asbestos. State Farm has offered to pay only about half of the \$102,000 that its own contractor estimated it would cost to thoroughly clean the house, Harrity said.

“So what you would find in our house is that nothing has been done,” she said. “If you entered, you would still see the school lunches I was making in the kitchen the night we evacuated.”

Six months after the Jan. 7 firestorms that killed at least 29 people and destroyed more than 16,000 structures, frustrations are mounting among many homeowners over how the state’s largest insurer is handling their damage claims.

Harrity and hundreds of other policyholders in the Eaton and Palisades fire zones relayed their complaints about their dealings with State Farm to the California Department of Insurance, calling for an investigation.

The homeowners complained anonymously of being shuffled to multiple inexperienced adjusters, feeling “ghosted” by unanswered questions.

[See [State Farm](#), A7]



THE YOUNG South Korean men who have drifted to the right see feminism as a problem, experts say.

Political rift widens for South Korea’s young men, women

By MAX KIM

SEOUL — It’s a worldwide shift that has taken political scientists and sociologists by surprise: the growing ideological divide between young men and women.

In the recent U.S. presidential election, President Trump won 56% of the vote among men ages 18 to 29, according to an analysis from Tufts University’s Center for Information & Research on Civic Learning and Engagement.

In Germany, young men are twice as likely as young

women to support the far-right Alternative for Germany party, or AfD, according to the Pew Research Center. Last year’s European Parliament elections showed a similar trend. According to the European Policy Center, in Portugal, Denmark and Croatia, more than four young men voted for far-right candidates for every young woman who did the same.

But few countries exemplify the trend more than South Korea, where a recent presidential election showed just how polarized its youth has become.

[See [South Korea](#), A4]

State’s Climate Superfund bills stall again

By HAYLEY SMITH

California lawmakers have for years vowed to hold fossil fuel companies liable for damages caused by their emissions, including worsening wildfires and floods and mounting costs of climate recovery and adaptation. But the state’s so-called Climate Superfund bills have once again stalled in Sacramento amid fierce lobbying and industry pressure — leaving communities to cover the costs.

The latest version of this effort, Senate Bill 684 and Assembly Bill 1243 — known as the Polluters Pay Climate Superfund Act — would require the largest oil and gas companies doing business in the state to pay their fair share of the damages caused by their emissions.

[See [Climate](#), A12]



STATE lawmakers have struggled to hold fossil fuel giants liable for emissions.

With ‘F1,’ Apple movies may be back on track
The Brad Pitt action flick was a gamble that could pay off for the company’s struggling film slate. **BUSINESS, A9**

UCLA, Cal take bear fight online
Both universities claim they’re No. 1 after U.S. News & World Report ratings. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

For the latest news, go to [latimes.com](#).

Business **A9**
Opinion Voices **A11**

Texas scrutinized on flood response
National Weather Service warned residents hours before dangerous conditions. **NATION, A5**

Dodgers swept by hated Astros
Taking all three games, Houston outscored L.A. 29-6 over the holiday weekend. **SPORTS, D1**

Weather
Sunshine.
L.A. Basin: 83/61. **B6**

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L.A.’s fruit-shaped desserts take the cake

Bakeries around town are lighting up social media with the colorful, lifelike treats.

By JENN HARRIS

More than 115 million people watched a video of French pastry chef Cédric Grolet make fruit pies that resemble giant blueberries, peaches, oranges and raspberries. A peach dessert molded and spray-painted to look like the real thing



AURORA pastry shop is known for its elaborateness.

drew 63.6 million views. Caramelized banana and peanut butter logs clumped together to mimic a bunch of bananas captivated nearly 33 million people.

Grolet is known for his trompe-l’œil desserts, elaborate creations constructed from various fruit, nut brittles, mousse, cake, creams, custards and chocolates. He’s created desserts that look like oversized peanuts, Buddha’s hands and just about every other nut, stone fruit and berry.

“These types of desserts have been around for a long time,” he said.

[See [Desserts](#), A8]